

THE APPROACH

The King's Crusade — Module Ten

OVERVIEW

The coalition's final march brings it within sight of Caer Ysolde — and for the first time since Landfall, the party sees what the deepest drainage actually looks like, at the scale of a capital rather than a mile of road. This module also introduces the resistance leader in person: the member of the royal house who escaped the fall of the kingdom and has refused every offer of evacuation since. Nothing here forces the campaign's central choice. It only makes sure the table has actually sat with it before Module Eleven asks. Core scenes run three and a half to four hours; Optional Content

fills out the rest of a five-hour session and can be cut cleanly if the table is short on time.

A QUIET MODULE ON PURPOSE

Resist adding combat to pad this module's length. Its entire job is weight and reflection after Module Nine's real cost, and a fight here would undercut that rather than serve it. If a table wants more to do, use Optional Content rather than inventing an encounter — this is one of the few modules in the campaign built to run under its target time without anything having gone wrong.

Scene	Target time	Notes
1. The Last Miles	20–30 min	The march's final stretch; accumulated weight, not new danger.
2. Caer Ysolde, Dark	30–40 min	First sight of the capital. The Standing Light has failed here.
3. The Regent	60–75 min	The resistance leader, met in person for the first time.
4. The Price	30–40 min	Doria Kell names what Norvatch wants. No combat; the module's hardest scene.
5. What Waits at the Gates	30–45 min	The turn-back-or-hold question, weighed narratively.
Optional Content	30–45 min	Run if the table has time; cut cleanly if not.

WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING (DM ONLY)

The Regent has spent three years running a resistance that could never win, on purpose — not to defeat the occupation, which was never possible with the forces available, but to make sure Elduvaine never became a place that had simply accepted Vale. They know a great deal about the deepest state of the drainage, about the Archive's vaults from the outside, and about what the rest of the royal house actually wants for the kingdom afterward, which is not something they all agree on. None of this resolves the campaign's central open question — what Elduvaine should become after the war — and this module should not resolve it either.

DM Only: the Regent is a real, developed person, not an exposition device — give them their own opinions, including ones the party might disagree with. Do not use them to state a “correct” answer to the turn-back-or-hold question; that question is deliberately left to the table, and a later session must not reweight it, including through this NPC's own persuasive certainty.

SCENE 1: THE LAST MILES

The road from the field battle to Caer Ysolde is the campaign's longest quiet stretch, and it should feel like one. Let the party notice how much has actually changed since Duncarrow: who they have lost, who they have freed, and how little any of it resembles the war they thought they were marching into.

Nobody talks much on the last day's march. It isn't grim exactly — more that everyone in the column seems to be doing the same private arithmetic, adding up what the last several months have actually cost against what they came here for, and none of them are quite ready to say the sum out loud.

This scene has no mechanical content. Let the party talk to whichever recurring NPCs the campaign has given them — the Ward, the Magistrate, Brenna Vane, Sera Vosk or Garrick Hollow, a captured Drell or Voss if either survived — about anything at all. This is the campaign giving its own cast room to be people rather than plot before the finale asks something of all of them.

SCENE 2: CAER YSOLDE, DARK

The column crests a final rise, and Caer Ysolde is below them — the capital where three rivers braid together, exactly as the sourcebook describes it, except for the one thing no description quite prepares a party for.

It is dark. Not ruined, not besieged-looking from this distance — simply dark, in a way a city its size has apparently never been before tonight, its pale stone holding no more light than any ordinary quarry's would. Somewhere down there is the Ysolde Archive, the largest collection of magical knowledge in the world, and the party is looking at the exact place the sourcebook already told them the draining hits first and hardest.

Let this land as the wonder-into-grief beat it is meant to be, deliberately paired against Module Three's Caerwyn glowing at dusk. If a player remarks on the contrast, that is the scene working exactly as intended — do not have an NPC explain it; let the silence around the column do that.

SCENE 3: THE REGENT

A resistance contact — cautious, testing the party before committing to anything — leads them to a meeting the coalition's own officers have been trying to arrange for weeks: the Regent, in person, for the first time.

They are older than the party expects, and plainer — no crown, no court dress, a coat as travel-worn as anything Doria Kell wears. "Three years I've been told, by people who mean well, that I should let myself be taken somewhere safe," they say, by way of greeting. "I have found that 'safe' and 'useful' are very rarely the same offer. You, I take it, are neither."

RUNNING THE SCENE

The Regent will speak plainly about what the resistance actually knows: the drainage's current state, Vale's general pattern of movement within the city (he is rarely seen, and never predictably), and, if asked directly, their own view on what should happen to Elduvaine after the war — a view the sourcebook establishes the royal house does not universally share. Let this be a real conversation with a real person who has earned the right to an opinion, not a briefing. No skill check gates any of this information; the Regent gives it freely to people they have decided, correctly, are worth trusting.

DM Only: if the party has freed the Ward and the Magistrate, this is a natural moment for the Regent to ask after them directly and personally rather than as political assets — let that land as real family feeling, complicated by three years apart and by disagreement about what comes next.

SCENE 4: THE PRICE

Before the coalition moves on Caer Ysolde, Doria Kell finds the party one more time — sent for, if they went looking after Vindana; arriving unannounced if they did not. She has brought a folio, a contract, and no small talk.

"Three years of purchase records," she says, setting the folio down but not letting go of it. "Everything Norvatch has bought out of this kingdom since the night the wards opened, by weight and by date. You want it because it is the only honest answer to the question none of your commanders can answer: how much of Elduvaine is actually left, and therefore how long you have."

"The price is a signature. Norvatch's trading rights in a liberated Elduvaine, guaranteed, in writing, by your king. He has no authority to give me that — I am aware. He had no authority to promise the Archive to Oksitan either, and he did it in front of witnesses, and here we all are."

This is the module's hardest scene and it has no combat in it. The information is real and Doria is not lying about any part of it: the ledgers say what she says they say, the price is exactly what she names, and Norvatch will honour whatever is signed to the letter and forever. Xavier will sign it if the party tells him to, and will look at them while he does it.

What it costs is not money. It is that the coalition has now promised the same kingdom three times — land to Oksitan, the Archive to Auberitz, and the standing right to buy the place by the cartload to a realm that never marched a single

soldier. Every one of those promises is only payable on an Elduvaine that is taken and held, and the party is one module away from deciding whether it will be.

DM Only: refusing is a real option with a real cost, and the module must not tilt it. A party that refuses walks into Module Eleven not knowing how much of the kingdom is left, which is exactly as frightening as it sounds and entirely survivable. A party that signs walks in knowing — and knowing, too, that they have made the settlement one degree harder for whoever has to write it. Neither is the correct answer. Record which in the Branch Ledger and move on without comment.

DM Only: if the party asks what the ledgers actually say, give them a real number and let it be worse than they hoped: somewhere near a third of the Living Realm's resident magic is already gone, the rate has been climbing for a year, and Vale is not slowing down. Do not translate that into a countdown of days. It is a direction of travel, not a timer, and the party should feel hurried rather than scheduled.

SCENE 5: WHAT WAITS AT THE GATES

Before the final push, let the coalition's leadership — and the party themselves — sit with the question the whole campaign has been building toward without answering: take Elduvaine, or, having proven it can be done, choose not to hold it.

Nobody puts it that bluntly. It comes out instead as smaller questions, asked by different people for different reasons — an Oksitan officer asking what happens to the Promise if the coalition marches home early; the Magistrate asking, very precisely, what "victory" is actually meant to mean here; Xavier, quieter than usual, asking the party directly whether they think this is a kingdom that wants saving on the coalition's terms.

Do not resolve this scene with a decision. Its entire purpose is to make sure the table has heard the question asked seriously, by people with real stakes in the answer, before Module Eleven makes them answer it. End the module on the coalition making final preparations — supply, formation, the ordinary business of an army about to do something enormous — and hand off directly to Module Eleven.

PUZZLES AND SET PIECES

Reading the Ledgers follows the price scene and adds twenty minutes, and only happens at all if the party bought the folio. The Regent's Council is the counsel scene, with the question turned around and put to the party instead.

THE PUZZLE: READING THE LEDGERS

If the party bought Doria Kell's folio, they now hold three years of purchase records and no idea what they mean. The arithmetic is the puzzle, the answer is a single number, and the number is worse than anybody hoped.

Norvatch records by weight and by date, not by kind, because Norvatch is buying tonnage and does not care what the tonnage was. Four columns and nothing else:

Year	Cut light-stone, tons	Other cargo, tons	What the party can work out
One	1,400	9,100	Ordinary trade, plus a little. This is close to a normal year for Vindana.
Two	6,800	8,900	The other cargo has not moved. The light-stone has gone up nearly fivefold.
Three	19,200	8,400	And again. The curve is not linear and has not flattened.

The insight is that the ordinary cargo is flat, which means Elduvaine's actual economy is unchanged and everything in the increase is the draining. And cut light-stone is not building stone: it is the medium, drained and packaged, and every ton of it is a piece of the Living Realm in a cart.

A character with the Archive Clerk or Season-Keeper background, or a DC 16 Intelligence check by anyone, converts it. Cairn Ithel's masons can say how much resident magic a ton of cut stone will hold. The Season-Keepers at Nantcorrow have the map of which woods have turned and in what order. Put the two together and the number comes out.

"Something near a third of it. A third of the Living Realm, gone through Vindana in three years, and the rate has been climbing every quarter and has not once slowed. That is what you have bought. I did tell you it was not good news. I only ever said it was true."

DM Only: give them the number and do not turn it into a countdown of days. It is a direction of travel, not a timer, and the party should feel hurried rather than scheduled. Two things follow that the DM should let land on their own: the curve is accelerating, which means the fourth year is worse than the first three combined; and a party that refused the folio walks into Module Eleven without any of this, which is exactly as frightening as it sounds and is entirely survivable. Neither is the correct answer and the module must not tilt it.

SET PIECE: THE REGENT'S COUNCIL

A miller, two orchard-keepers, a forger who used to file requisitions, and the last free member of the royal house of Elduvaine, in the back of a lock-house eleven miles from the capital, deciding what to ask the coalition for.

"There are seven of us and a table. Aveline Ysolde is at the head of it because somebody has to be, not because anyone here would call her that out loud, and she has a list in front of her in a hand so small it is almost a cipher. She does not stand up when you come in. She says: sit down, we have four hours, and I would like to know what your king thinks he has promised, because we have heard three versions and none of them can all be true."

She is right. The party has watched Xavier promise land to Oksitan, the Archive to Auberitz, and — if they signed in this module — the standing right to buy the kingdom by the cartload to a realm that never marched a soldier. Every one of those is only payable on an Elduvaine that is taken and held. Nobody asked Elduvaine.

What the resistance wants to know, in order: what the coalition has been promised. Who is expected to pay it. Whether the Concord's Tenth Work is going to be permitted to do what it has been openly saying it will do. And whether the party will tell them the truth about any of it.

The party can lie. It works. Aveline is not a lie detector and the meeting ends warmly and the resistance opens every

door in the Braid for them. It also means the first time an Elduvish parish watches a Tenth Work chapter house go up on ground that had an Observance on it, somebody in that room will remember who said it would not happen.

DM Only: there is no check to pass here and nothing to win. This is the campaign asking the party, once, directly, what they actually think the crusade is for, in front of the people it is nominally being fought for. Whatever they say goes in the Branch Ledger verbatim. Do not editorialise, do not have Aveline approve or disapprove, and do not resolve it in this module or the next one.

NPC PROFILES

THE REGENT

Human, in a family that mostly is not, and the only member of Elduvaine's royal house who was outside a wall when the wards opened. No proper name yet assigned, for the same reason as the Ward and the Magistrate (see the DM-Only note in What Is Actually Happening). Speech: measured, unsentimental, entirely unbothered by three years of danger that would have broken most people. Has genuinely considered leaving Elduvaine and genuinely chosen not to, more than once.

Open thread: the Regent's own view on Elduvaine's future is theirs to hold and the campaign's not to adjudicate — a DM developing the endgame should treat their opinion as one real voice among several in the royal house, not the deciding one.

OPTIONAL CONTENT

THE RESISTANCE, BRIEFLY

The Regent's people are exactly as unglamorous as the kingdom that produced them: a halfling miller who has been miscounting the levy for two years, two elven orchard-keepers who between them have hidden eleven people, a gnome who used to file Archive requisitions and now forges permits with the same handwriting. Nobody here is a soldier. All of them have been committing small, patient, deniable treason since before the coalition sailed.

If the table wants more of Elduvaine's ordinary resistance before the finale, let them meet a handful of the Regent's people directly — farmers, former Archive clerks, people who have been doing small, unglamorous sabotage for three years rather than anything a story would call heroic. No mechanical stakes; pure texture, and a chance to make the liberated feel like people rather than a cause.

LETTERS HOME

If the table wants a quiet character scene, let each PC write (or dictate, or simply compose in their head) a letter home before the finale — to Harrowmark, to wherever they came from, to whoever they left behind. No mechanical content; this is purely for the players who want a moment of reflection before the campaign's climax.

DIVERGING PATHS (DM ONLY)

- **Whether Xavier signed Norvatch's contract.** Signed, refused, or deferred — track which, and who in the party argued for it. A signed contract means the coalition has promised the same kingdom three times and the party knows how much of Elduvaine is left; a refusal means they walk into the finale without that number. This is the last entry added before the campaign's final choice and it bears directly on it.
- **What the party told the Regent, and what the Regent told them.** Not mechanically trackable in the usual sense, but worth a DM's private note — this conversation is the table's clearest signal yet of which way they are leaning on the campaign's central question, and it is worth remembering going into Module Eleven.

LOOT

- **Nothing material.** This module, like Module Three and Module Five before it, is not about treasure. Its currency is entirely the conversation in Scenes 3 and 4.

THE REFRAIN

*By thought, and by word, and by deed,
the king's own chosen kept their creed.
Far from home, where the quiet land lay,
they held the line, and would not stray.*